

Pro-drop in interrogative structures in Old Italian, Old High German, and Old French

1. Introduction

The aim of this paper is to investigate the distribution of null subjects in main interrogative clauses in Old Italian (OI), Early Old French (EOF) and Old High German (OHG). These are all languages characterized by i) V2 rule, and ii) the presence of asymmetric pro-drop. We will show that while OHG and OI have very different configurations of the left periphery, EOF has a structure that lies between the two others.

2. Null subjects in asymmetric null-subject languages

Since Benincà (1984) and Adams (1987) it has been known that Old Romance languages were characterized by the presence of so-called asymmetric *pro*-drop, i.e. null subjects were typically found in main clauses and much rarer in embedded clauses.

- (1) E così ne provò _ de' più cari ch'elli avea.
and so of-it tested.3sg of-the most dear that-he had
'So he tested some of the best friends he had.'
(Old Florentine, Benincà 2006: 68; *Testi fiorentini*, 74)

- (2) Et lors le prent _ par la main si descendent dou palais
and then him take _ by the hand si descend of-the palace
'And then he took him by the hand and they descended from the palace.'
(Old French, qgraal_cm, col. 162c, l. 12)

The facts in (1) are traditionally captured through a syntactic account according to which *pro* is licensed via government through V-to-C movement (Roberts 1993, Vance 1997; see also Axel 2007 to a similar hypothesis for asymmetric pro-drop in Old High German). According to the V-to-C hypothesis, null subjects can only be licensed in main clauses because this clause type involves V-to-C movement – an option that is blocked in embedded clauses due to the fact that the position hosting the finite verb in main clauses hosts the complementiser (den Besten 1983).

This analysis, which relies on the Government and binding approach of the 80' has been challenged first for Germanic (Walkden 2014) and then for Romance (Cognola 2015, Cognola/Walkden in press). According to these recent works, which rely on Frascarelli's (2007, 2018) and Sigurðsson (2011) analysis of pro-drop, V-to-C movement is not a sufficient condition for *pro* to be licensed. For a null subject to be licensed, on the contrary, *pro* always has to establish a matching relation with an XP in the left periphery. In the case of a third person, this XP will be an Aboutness-Shift topic (Frascarelli 2018: 212); in the case of 1-2 persons it will be a logophoric operator (Sigurðsson (2011). When continuous, the aboutness topic can be null. According to this approach, one condition is vital for the licensing of a null subject, i.e. the structure of the left periphery: if a TopicP/operator position is available in CP, then *pro* will be licensed. This condition is mostly met in main clauses which have the richer structure of the left periphery (see Haegeman 2004 for asymmetries between main and embedded clauses).

3. Main interrogative clauses

With the exception of Cognola/Walkden (2019) no study has been devoted to investigating the distribution of pro-drop in main interrogative clauses in asymmetric pro-drop languages. This clause type is key to both the syntactic account and to the Topic-matching hypothesis, which, however, make opposite predictions about the distribution of null subjects across main declarative and interrogative clauses:

- (3) **a. Syntactic analysis:** the percentage of *pro*-drop should be higher in interrogatives than in declaratives since they are the prototypical V2 environment (Rizzi 1994), or there should be

no relevant differences between interrogatives and main clauses

b. Topic-matching hypothesis: the percentage of *pro*-drop might be lower than in main clauses because an operator (*wh*) is hosted in the left periphery and this might interfere with the matching relation between topic/logophoric operator and *pro*.

Cognola & Walkden (in press) show for Old Italian and Old High German that null subjects are found in around 90% of main declarative clauses and in 30% (OHG) and 44% (OI) of interrogative clauses – which confirms the predictions of the Topic-matching analysis.

Moreover, Cognola & Walkden (in press) show that:

- (4) **a.** *pro*-drop is favoured in OHG by person type 2 ps (see Weiss & Volodina 2018) irrespective of *wh*-interrogative type;
- b.** *pro*-drop is favoured in OI by *wh*-interrogative type, with *why*, *what* (obj) and *how* clauses showing the highest percentage of null subjects.

Cognola & Walkden (in press) propose that the asymmetry between OHG and OI follows from the fact that:

- (5) **a.** OI already exhibits a rich structure of the left periphery like the one found in the present-day language (Benincà 2006);
- b.** In OI *wh* elements hosted in the lower portion of CP (FinP or FocusP) count as interveners for the matching relation between *pro* and the Topic/logophoric operator;
- c.** *wh* elements hosted higher (like *why*, hosted in InterrogativeP see Rizzi 2001) do not count as interveners, possibly because they are merged directly in CP.
- d.** In OHG the left periphery is built of only two FPs: a higher one hosting the logophoric operator/topic and a lower one hosting the *wh*-element;
- e.** a matching relation can always be established between *pro* in TP and the XP in the highest FP of the periphery pending the presence of rich agreement on the verb, i.e. when strong *phi*-features are expressed by the verbal ending.

Bearing this in mind, we turn to OF. OF is an interesting case as it is a Romance language that has been claimed to have a Germanic-like syntax (Mathieu 2006). In Wolfe's typology, Early OF is a Fin-V2 language, while later OF is a Force-V2 language (Wolfe 2015, 2018). In the 13th century (Force-V2 stage), there is hardly any *pro* drop in interrogative structures (Meklenborg Salvesen, 2015), so we have selected two of the oldest texts, *La Chanson de Roland* and *Quatre Livres des Rois* in order to look at possible *pro* drop in interrogative contexts. In these two texts, 50.5 % of the direct questions have *pro* drop. Just as we saw in OI, *pro* drop typically occurs with *wh* words meaning 'why' (85.5 %), 'how' (46.2 %) 'what' (65.1 %), but also after 'which' (63.2 %). In yes/no-questions, the percentage is 30.8. Further, we find that *pro* drop is by and large more common after the 1st and 2nd persons than after the 3rd. We interpret these findings in the following way

- (6) **a.** EOF (like OI) has a rich left periphery;
- b.** In EOF, there is only one, low position for *wh* elements, like in OHG.
- c.** there is a designated projection above WhP that can host the logophoric operator/topic (which can also be overt)
- d.** Like in OHG, there can always be a matching relation between *pro* in TP and the XP in the highest FP of the periphery
- e.** This matching relation is related to the presence of strong *phi*-features are expressed by the verbal ending.

In other words, data from OF support an analysis which places OF between OHG and OI. In the next step of this work, we will sketch out the development in later stages of the languages in question.